

Curatorial Text MusraraMix

The MusraraMix Festival is an international multidisciplinary event that takes place in the borderline neighborhood of Musrara, initiated and produced by Musrara, the Naggat School of Art and Society. The festival is a hub of artistic and social happenings, embodying the political and cultural essence of Jerusalem and Israel. Every year the Festival is based around one theme. The 22th year of the Festival is the year of High Tones.

The Festival expresses the School's outlook. We believe in the significant role the creative process has, when it turns our gaze onto society and the identities that structure it. We believe in the power the festival has, as part of the educational process of the students. Musrara, The Naggat School of Art and Society, invites the public to participate in the events taking place during the festival, to experience the neighborhood, explore its streets, be a guest in the backyards, meet the residents and enjoy some of the best multidisciplinary made in Israel and the world today. We would like to thank our partners: firstly the residents of Musrara, the public and private funds and organizations from Israel and abroad that sponsor our activities, and of course our students, teachers and school staff.

2019 Displacement

Displacement, shift, parallax, removal, and mobility are all different forms of dislocation and repositioning, whether by choice or duress. Human and natural systems are constantly shifting due to survival and struggle processes; Biological, physical, or mental processes; And developmental processes of transformation, reproduction, and liberation; Subjects and objects are formed in processes of ongoing, voluntary and involuntary, movement, where sequences are created and interrupted, and consequently images, artistic actions, and meanings are continuously repositioned. If we look at basic linguistic mechanisms of understanding and producing meaning, the act of displacement sets the original meaning in an ongoing process of concealing and revealing, within a relation of substitution and "placeholdering." In this sense, the act of displacement allows us to discover new knowledge about the world and establish a platform for critical inquiry. In the current geopolitical reality, the act of displacement is associated with violence and force, introducing urgent issues of migration, uprooting, expropriation, and gentrification.

There are also spaces that were subjected to deterritorialization, becoming anti-places or nonplaces that have no "memory" or "history." In a psychoanalytical context, the term displacement can be traced back to Freud's theories of subconscious defense mechanisms and technique of dream interpretation and therapy. Building on Freud, Lacan considered the act of displacement to be a seminal principle of the unconscious world, an expression of the

insatiable desire for the lack. The worlds of dreams, fantasy, and science fiction also originate in this desire.

In the world of science, parallax – the human ability to see something at a distance from different perspectives and the illusion that distant things move slower than those closer to us –

is how our minds gain depth perception. Parallax serves as an astronomical tool for observing and measuring distances in space and is utilized for military functions, as well as in contemporary photography technologies and digital video games.

At its essence, dislocation is the transition from the previous stage, which was relevant to the reality in which it existed, to the current reality. Migration, nomadism, and mobility are associated with aspects of the animal world, genetics, and ecology. At the same time, they are basic concepts that pertain to ways of life and cultural, information, language, technology, capital, and economic exchange on a global level (one example is the use of “roaming” in reference to data migration from one communication network to another).

These concepts capture basic outlooks and tensions in the life of the individual and society in Israel and around the world: notions of transience and challenging physical and conceptual boundaries as new

possibilities for social relationships; False or real freedom and the eternal outsider’s perspective of the nomad, the mobile man versus the orderly, rational, and controlled stationary life;

Concepts of migration, refugeehood, belonging and rootlessness, global tourism, and fantasies of passion, as well as journeys of exploration – both of the self and of the other.

This year at Musrara Mix #19 we will look at displacement in terms of dislocation, shift, mobility and migration through a plethora of discourse and research disciplines. Conversion and

nomadism, expropriation and deterritorialization, disassembly and reconstruction – concepts and thought patterns that play a key role in contemporary artistic discourse, the media,

science, philosophy, and psychoanalysis. The artists will bring their creative processes into the exhibition venues, spilling into the streets, courtyards and trails throughout Musrara neighborhood, with the aim of creating new possibilities for addressing and discussing the meanings of these notions and the critical and poetic understanding of their role in our lives.

High Tones 21

All art is a protest and every work of art protests against something in reality. Over centuries of cultural creation, artists persistently turned the spotlight towards silenced areas in society and sought ways to express the voices that are not heard. With that, art challenges the existing situation while anticipating what is yet to come. Like a constant protest today against yesterday, trying to prevent the replication of reality and even wishing to repair it through an alternative proposition.

Protests play an important role in the political development of countries. Today, in the world of social media, protest no longer requires physical space and can even undermine the digital medium that has become a means of protest as well as control. At the same time, the question of protest's impact on political processes is incredibly complex and often called into question, as is the effectiveness of art as a form of protest. There numerous intersections are clear and obvious, however in contrast to political activism, artworks have the power to directly address the individual's psyche through channels that are not necessarily verbal, to offer new perspectives that transgress conventions, and with that, challenge institutions and power relations in society.

Musrara Mix 21 will take place in December 2021. This year the school marks the jubilee of the Israel Black Panthers movement, the first social protest movement in Israel that formed in the early 1970s in Musrara neighborhood – where the school has been operating for over 30 years, and where the festival takes place. Fifty years have passed since the protest first broke out and it seems that the riots, conflicts, and cultural, political, and ethnic disparities continue to resonate through the Israeli society, and to some extent, are still bubbling beneath the surface. These meet with profound changes at the international level. It seems that society and culture are facing an imminent change: from the global pandemic and the new political-economic reality built on the fragments of the crumbling reality of the “post-truth” and “fake news” era, through

ecological disasters, financial crises, and recurring elections in the shadow of lockdown and the pink protest at Balfour, to the tensions and disillusion in Israel's mixed cities. These events have brought about a deep crisis in the cultural sphere that also impacts questions about the public and the private space.

In the spirit of longing for an equal and critical cultural-social space, this year the festival will be held in the community center and its surroundings with live art, performance, and participatory works, generating a re-examination of the space in which we live. The festival will touch on distinct political issues as well as the most profound aspects of the individual's subjective identity and its construction, and will feature artists who explore the body as a private space that has the power to express protest. Protest that is not necessarily political in the conventional sense but rather one that pulsates with the freedom of artistic expression and allows artists the space for independent and biting expression.

High Tones²²

All art is a protest and every work of art protests against some aspect or element of reality. For centuries, artists persistently turned the spotlight towards silenced areas in society and amplified the voices that are not heard. With that, art challenges existing orders while anticipating what is yet to come. Like a constant protest today against yesterday, trying to prevent the replication of reality and even wishing to repair it through alternative propositions. The 22nd Musrara Mix Festival adds another layer to the examination of protests and forms of protest in art, centering on the Israeli Black Panthers protest that erupted in Musrara neighborhood 50 years ago. Despite the decades that have passed since, it seems that the period's zeitgeist, conflicts, and cultural, political, and ethnic disparities continue to resonate through the Israeli society. These encounter profound international shifts and challenges, from the global pandemic and the new political-economic reality that emerged from the fragments

of the crumbling reality in the “post-truth” and “fake news” era, through ecological disasters, financial crises, and recurring elections in the shadow of lockdowns and the pink protest at Balfour, to the tensions and disillusion in Israel’s mixed cities. These events have brought about a deep rift in the cultural sphere that also impacts questions about the public and the private space.

The festival, which will take place in May 2022, expands the exploration of protests and modes of protest in art, focusing on the impact of technology on defiance as well as art’s response to technology, and to the power and privileges it entails. Protests have a critical role in the political development of countries, but today, in a world of social media, protests do not depend on the physical space and can even undermine the digital medium – which serves as a tool of protest as well as policing and control.

In the spirit of the longing for an equal and critical cultural-social space, this year the festival will be held in the community center and the historical building of the school with live art, performance, and participatory works, generating a re-examination of the physical and virtual space in which we exist. The festival will touch on distinct political issues as well as the most profound aspects of the individual’s subjective identity and its construction, and will feature artists who explore the radical transformations brought about by the interaction between technological progress to culture and society in the language of protest as well as personal expressions.

2023 Small World

It is fascinating to see how the rich and diverse world of tiny creatures like insects, reptiles, and vermin affects so many aspects of human culture. We domesticate insects, use them to decorate our habitat, utilize them and their products for our needs, regulate their activity to help cultivate our crops and lead our lives alongside them, sometimes in complete disregard and other time in true symbiosis.

Musca depicta, which means “painted fly” in Latin, is a symbolic motif that gained popularity in Dutch and Northern Renaissance painting in the 15th century. Depicting a fly on or around a portrait symbolized the worthy and significant in the smallest of God’s creations. In the following centuries, this developed into a tradition of painting insects on flower arrangements, as well as worms emerging out of plump apples or various delicacies. The presence of the small critters that gnaw away at the still life and the cultural order signified the eternal nature of art versus the ephemeral painted – and painting body. Indeed, throughout the history of both Western and Eastern art, insects have inspired many artists who marveled at their

appearance and unusual behavior. The artistic focus on these creatures reflects their prominence in our world – not only in science, industry, and agriculture, but as a part of our everyday life environment.

This year, the 23rd Musrara Mix Festival features performances, audio-visual displays, video works, music, noise and new music shows, robotics and interactive art that present the possibility to look at the world, even if for a moment, through the different and strange eyes of insects. The works draw on the extensive and disturbing history of creepy crawlies that come out of the dark, address the new ecological reality that requires that we understand how the flapping of a butterfly's wings affects us, and examine the relationship between the individual and the group, the micro and macro, nocturnal and daytime life. Over the three days of the festival, the participating artists will weave new expressions of our relationship with the fantastical world of insects.